were so weak as not to be able to ride or hang on a horse, I was obliged to abandon them to the knives of those merciless villains who gloried in cutting the throats of poor emaciated helpless beings. Every march we passed the bodies of those abandoned by the columns ahead of us.'[112]

In Jalalabad, Chamberlain arrived in time to see Broadfoot's engineers mining the walls of the fortress they had twice rebuilt and then defended with such success. A massive charge was placed under each bastion, and smaller ones along each stretch of curtain.[113] On 27 October, immediately after Pollock had marched out, there was a colossal explosion and Jalalabad was left as Kabul had been before it, a smoking mass of ruins.[114]

It was on the next stage of the retreat, the descent of the Khyber, that the British encountered the most determined resistance. The Afridis as usual streamed out of their mountain villages to snipe, gut and pillage the passing columns, and again the British exacted bloody reprisals. 'No quarter was given,' scribbled Chamberlain on the night of the 29th. 'We killed between 150 and 200 men . . . All the stacks and villages plundered and fired.' On 1 November, at the top of the pass, John Nicholson was briefly reunited with his younger brother Alexander, before John was sent to join Chamberlain in the rearguard.

The following day, Chamberlain and John Nicholson corkscrewed down the path just below Ali Masjid, accompanied by the chaplain Allen. Turning a sharp corner the three found the road thickly strewn with the bodies of their colleagues from whom they had parted the previous afternoon. Their entire party had been trapped and overwhelmed by an Afridi ambush. Now their remains were 'lying here and there, stripped and mangled, some already partially devoured by dogs and birds of prey. Among them were two native women, one young and well looking.'[115] Among the dead was Nicholson's younger brother. His body was stark naked, and hacked to pieces. In accordance with Afridi custom, Alexander had had his genitalia cut off and stuffed in his mouth.[116] The incident left Nicholson with a visceral, almost psychopathic loathing of all Muslims, and with an appetite for their destruction that he was able to indulge in periodically over the next few years, and slake fully during the Great Uprising of 1857.[117]

The next morning, his last in Afghanistan, it was Chamberlain's turn to be ambushed. He was again in the rearguard and as he descended the final section of the road towards the fort at Jamrud his party were caught in a hail